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Documents

Richard Nelson, "The Watchful World"

Reprinted from *Make Prayers to the Raven: A Koyukon View of the Northern Forest* (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1983)

Because most pre-Columbian Indians did not have a written language, there are few primary sources that describe their understandings of the natural

world. For this reason, we're going to turn first to an anthropologist's account of Indians and their views on nature. Technically, what we are looking at here is a secondary source, which describes how American Indian hunters, the Koyukon people of Alaska, understood the natural world.

There are at least two limitations to the usefulness of this document. First, it is by a white anthropologist, Richard Nelson, so we must remind ourselves that we are actually receiving this account of the Koyukon world view second hand. Nelson often quotes Koyukon people's descriptions of their beliefs from interviews he had with them (these appear in italics). But he also quotes his own thoughts as recorded in his journal during his research (these appear in roman, and end with "Huslia Journal," and the date of the entry). Be careful not to confuse the two.

Second, Nelson was describing Koyukon beliefs of the 1970s. To assume that Indian beliefs of the distant past were similar to the 1970s Koyukon views is risky. Indian peoples were and are culturally diverse. Just because a community of people in Alaska thought in particular ways in the 1970s does not mean that their ancestors of centuries back, much less Indians living thousands of miles away at the same time, thought similarly. (Would your modern-day beliefs about religion and nature be a good indicator of the convictions of your ancestors in, say, 1490?) Nevertheless, other evidence suggests that historical Indian beliefs had many parallels to Koyukon religion. Richard Nelson provides us with a coherent interpretation of Indian natural understandings, and for this reason his account remains one of the most useful introductions to the subject.

Nelson describes a perception of nature that was alive and well at the time he lived amongst the Koyukon. The way of life and world view he describes are in fact still vigorous, especially in the remote reaches of Alaska, the Canadian north, and even in places in the continental United States. In this sense, the cultural world he sketches for us here is part of modern America – thinking about it as just "history" would mean missing one of the most important insights which environmental history has to offer: that not all people think about nature in the same way. Nelson is attempting to present us with a view of nature through Koyukon eyes. Whatever else we say about his interpretation, there is no doubt that Koyukon people see the natural world as a universe of spirits, most of them having great and potentially dangerous powers. Environmental history often leads us, in surprising ways, to the connections between peoples and their creators.

What in the Koyukon view of nature strikes you as different from your own understandings of nature? Is the Koyukon world generally more "natural" than your world? And is "nature" one thing among the Koyukon? Or is it a whole world of separate entities, spirits, presences, and forces? Do different parts of Koyukon nature have different meanings?

* * *

There's always things in the air that watch us.

A Way of Seeing

. . . Traditional Koyukon people live in a world that watches, in a forest of eyes. A person moving through nature – however wild, remote, even desolate the place may be – is never truly alone. The surroundings are aware, sensate, personified. They feel. They can be offended. And they must, at every moment, be treated with proper respect. All things in nature have a special kind of life, something unknown to contemporary Euro-Americans, something powerful. . . .

Over a span of millennia, the Koyukon people and their ancestors have sustained themselves directly from their surroundings. The intimacy of their relationship to nature is far beyond our experience – the physical dependence and the intense emotional interplay with a world that cannot be directly altered to serve the needs of humanity. This close daily interaction and dependence upon an omnipotent natural universe has profound importance to the Koyukon people and provides a theme upon which their cultural lives converge.

Koyukon perceptions of nature are aligned on two interconnected levels. The first of these is empirical knowledge. The practical challenges of survival by hunting, fishing, and gathering require a deep objective understanding of the environment and the methods for utilizing its resources. In short, the Koyukon people are sophisticated natural historians, especially well versed in animal behavior and ecology.

But their perception of the natural environment extends beyond what Westerners define as the empirical level, into the realm of the spiritual. The Koyukon inherit an elaborate system of supernatural concepts for explaining and manipulating the environment. From this perspective the natural and supernatural worlds are inseparable, and environmental events are often caused or influenced by spiritual forces. Detailed explanations are provided for the origin of natural entities and for the causation of natural events (which seldom, if ever, take place purely by chance). Furthermore, behavior toward nature is governed by an array of supernaturally based rules that ensure the well-being of both humans and the environment.

It is important to understand that Koyukon beliefs about nature are as logical and consistent as they are powerful, but that they differ substantially from those prevailing in modern Western societies. Our own tradition envisions the universe as a system whose functioning can be

explained through rationalistic and scientific means. The natural and supernatural worlds are clearly separated. Environmental events are caused by ongoing evolutionary and ecological processes, or else they happen purely by chance. Finally, modern Western cultures regulate human behavior toward nature and its resources primarily on the basis of practical rather than religious considerations.

For the traditional Koyukon Athapaskans, ideology is a fundamental element of subsistence, as important as the more tangible practicalities of harvesting and utilizing natural resources. Most interactions with natural entities are governed in some way by a moral code that maintains a proper spiritual balance between the human and nonhuman worlds. This is not an esoteric abstraction, but a matter of direct, daily concern to the Koyukon people. Failure to behave according to the dictates of this code can have an immediate impact on the violator's health or success. And so, when Koyukon people carry out their subsistence activities they make many decisions on the basis of supernatural concerns. The world is ever aware.

From the Distant Time

As the Koyukon reckon it, all things human and natural go back to a time called *Kk'adonts'idnee*, which is so remote that no one can explain or understand how long ago it really was. But however ancient this time may be, its events are recounted accurately and in great detail through a prodigious number of stories. *Kk'adonts'idnee* (literally, "in Distant Time it is said") is the Koyukon word for these stories, but following from its conversational use I will translate it simply as Distant Time.

The stories constitute an oral history of the Koyukon people and their environment, beginning in an age before the present order of existence was established. During this age "the animals were human" – that is, they had human form, they lived in a human society, and they spoke human (Koyukon) language. At some point in the Distant Time certain humans died and were transformed into animal or plant beings, the species that inhabit Koyukon country today. These dreamlike metamorphoses left a residue of human qualities and personality traits in the north-woods creatures.

Taken together, the Distant Time stories describe a primordial world and its transfiguration into modern form. Some are so long that a single narration may require many evenings, even several weeks of evenings, for a complete telling. Stories of this kind – widely known as legends, myths, or folklore – are found throughout North America and elsewhere. It is common practice, however, to vastly underrate their significance in

the lives of people like the Koyukon. They are not regarded as simple entertainment (though they are appreciated as such), and they are certainly not considered fictional. Stories of the Distant Time are, first of all, an accounting of origins. They are a Koyukon version of Genesis, or perhaps of Darwin. Woven into the plots of many stories are innumerable subplots or asides, which often describe the origins of natural entities.

The scope of Distant Time stories ranges from the minute to the cosmological. They explain the beginnings of entities that inhabit the sky – the sun, moon, and aurora. They account for certain weather phenomena, such as thunderstorms, which are the transformed embodiment of a formerly human spirit. For this reason thunderstorms have consciousness and can be turned away by people who know how to influence them. Features of the earth, such as prominent hills or mountains, are also given some accounting in these stories. For example, a hill near Huslia is called "Giant's Firemakers" (*Yiłkuh tł' aala'*), because it was formed when a giant man lost his flints there.

A central figure in this ancient world was the Raven (it is unclear, perhaps irrelevant, whether there was one Raven or many), who was its creator and who engineered many of its metamorphoses. Raven, the contradiction – omnipotent clown, benevolent mischief-maker, buffoon, and deity. It was he, transformed into a spruce needle, who was swallowed by a woman so she would give birth to him as a boy. When the boy was old enough to play, he took from beneath a blanket in her house the missing sun and rolled it to the door. Once outside, he became Raven again and flew up to return the sun to the sky, making the earth light again.

And it was he who manipulated the natural design to suit his whim or fancy. When he first created the earth, for example, the rivers ran both ways, upstream on one side and downstream on the other. But this made life too easy for humans, he decided, because their boats could drift along in either direction without paddling. So Raven altered his creation and made the rivers flow only one way, which is how they remain today.

There are hundreds of stories explaining the behavior and appearance of living things. Most of these are about animals and a few are about plants. No species is too insignificant to be mentioned, but importance in the Koyukon economy does not assure a prominent place in the stories. Many of the stories about animal origins are like this one:

> *When the burbot* [ling cod] *was human, he decided to leave the land and become a water animal. So he started down the bank, taking a piece of bear fat with him. But the other animal people wanted him to stay and tried to hold him back, stretching him all out of shape in the process. This is why the burbot has such a long, stretched-out body, and why its liver is rich and oily like the bear fat its ancestor carried to the water long ago.*

At the end of Distant Time there was a great catastrophe. The entire earth was covered by a flood, and under the Raven's supervision a pair of each species went aboard a raft. These plants and animals survived, but when the flood ended they could no longer behave like people. All the Distant Time humans had been killed, and so Raven recreated people in their present form. My Koyukon teachers were well aware of the biblical parallel in this story, and they took it as added evidence of the story's accuracy. None suggested that it might be a reinterpretation of Christian teaching.

Distant Time stories were usually told by older people who had memorized the lengthy epics and could best interpret them. But children were also taught stories, simpler ones that they were encouraged to tell, especially as they began to catch game. Doing this after setting out their traps or snares would please the animals and make them willing to be caught.

Today's elders can recall the long evenings of their youth, when Distant Time stories made the hours of darkness pass easily. In those days houses were lit by burning bear grease in a shallow bowl with a wick, or by burning long wands of split wood, one after another. Bear grease was scarce, and the hand-held wands were inconvenient, so in midwinter the dwellings were often dark after twilight faded. Faced with long wakeful hours in the blackness, people crawled into their warm beds and listened to the recounting of stories.

The narratives were reserved for late fall and the first half of winter, because they were tabooed after the days began lengthening. Not surprisingly, the teller finished each story by commenting that he or she had shortened the winter: "I thought that winter had just begun, but now I have chewed off part of it." Or, more optimistically, "When I woke up in the morning, my cabin was just dripping with water!" In this case the narrator implies that the spring thaw has suddenly begun.

Distant Time stories also provide the Koyukon with a foundation for understanding the natural world and humanity's proper relationship to it. When people discuss the plants, animals, or physical environment they often refer to the stories. Here they find explanations for the full range of natural phenomena, down to the smallest details. In one story a snowshoe hare was attacked by the hawk owl, which was so small that it only managed to make a little wound in its victim's shoulder. Koyukon people point out a tiny notch in the hare's scapula as evidence that the Distant Time events really took place.

The narratives also provide an extensive code of proper behavior toward the environment and its resources. They contain many episodes showing that certain kinds of actions toward nature can have bad consequences, and these are taken as guidelines to follow today. Stories

therefore serve as a medium for instructing young people in the traditional code and as an infallible standard of conduct for everyone.

Nobody made it up, these things we're supposed to do. It came from the stories; it's just like our Bible. My grandfather said he told the stories because they would bring the people good luck, keep them healthy, and make a good life. When he came to songs in the stories, he sang them like they were hymns.

The most important parts of the code are taboos (*hutlaanee*), prohibitions against acting certain ways toward nature. For example, in one story a salmon-woman was scraping skins at night with her upper jaw, and while doing this she was killed. This is why it is taboo for women to scrape hides during the night. Hundreds of such taboos exist, and a person who violates them (or someone in the immediate family) may suffer bad luck in subsistence activities, clumsiness, illness, accident, or early death. In Koyukuk River villages it is a rare day when someone is not heard saying, "*Hutlanee!*" ("It's taboo!").

Personalities in Nature

Stories of the Distant Time often portray the animal-people as having distinctive personalities, and this affects the way a species is regarded today. Often these personalities can be known only through the stories, because the animals do not visibly express them any longer. People sometimes have strong positive or negative feelings about particular species because of the way they are portrayed in the stories.

The sucker fish, for example, was a great thief in the Distant Time and so it is not well thought of. One man told me he could never bring himself to eat this fish, knowing what it had been and fearing that it would make a thief of him:

Even in springtime, sometimes we run short of food. But if we catch a sucker in the net, I just can't eat him.

People will sometimes characterize someone by referring to an animal's personality. In fact, Jetté . . . writes that Yukon River Koyukon may inquire about a person by asking, "What animal is he?" Someone known as a thief may be described as "just like a sucker fish." When a person talks big, promises a lot but accomplishes little, or gets ahead by trickery, he or she is said to be "just like a raven." Although Raven is the creator, he is portrayed in the stories as a lazy trickster who usually finds a way to get ahead by the efforts of others. The Koyukon have a kind of jocular

respect for ravens, mocking their personality but still awed by their spirit power.

When I asked about relatedness among animals, people usually answered with reference to their social behavior and personality. For example, a Distant Time story reveals that bears and porcupines are cousins, and people cite as proof their occasional sharing of a den. When relatedness is not mentioned in a story it may be revealed by a tendency to "get along." Muskrats and beavers often live close together and they eat the same kinds of plants, so they are considered relatives. Wolves may kill a loose dog, which shows that the two are not related.

Animal relationships are also shown by shared characteristics, but usually not those chosen by Western taxonomists. One story of the Distant Time says that all the smaller animals were related as sisters who lived together in an underground house. These included red squirrel, mink, fox, several owl species, short-tailed weasel, ptarmigan, and others. Another related group includes the four water mammals: otter, mink, beaver, and muskrat. Stories also reveal that the raven is mink's uncle. And in obviously paired species, the larger is considered the older brother to the smaller – brown bear to the black bear, for example, and flicker to the woodpecker.

The Koyukon people conceptualize a natural order, but its structure and foundation are quite different from our own. No one described to me a system of phylogeny or biological interrelatedness, but I did not probe this matter exhaustively and may have failed to ask the right questions. Such a system might exist, or perhaps the world's makeup is sufficiently explained in the stories.

The Place of Humans in a Natural Order

When Raven created humans, he first used rock for the raw materials, and people never died. But this was too easy so he recreated them, using dust instead. In this way humans became mortal, as they remain today.

How does humanity fit into the world of nature and the scheme of living things? For the Koyukon, humans and animals are clearly and qualitatively separated. Only the human possesses a soul (*nukk'ubidza*, "eye flutterer"), which people say is different from the animals' spirits. I never understood the differences, except that the human soul seems less vengeful and it alone enjoys immortality in a special place after death. The distinction between animals and people is less sharply drawn than in Western thought – the human organism, after all, was created by an animal's power.

The Koyukon seem to conceptualize humans and animals as very similar beings. This derives not so much from the animal nature of humans as from the human nature of animals. I noted earlier, for example, that today's animals once belonged to an essentially human society, and that transmutations between human and animal form were common. One of my Koyukon teachers said, however, that after the Distant Time people and animals became completely separate and unrelated.

Animals still possess qualities that Westerners consider exclusively human, though – they have a range of emotions, they have distinct personalities, they communicate among themselves, and they understand human behavior and language. They are constantly aware of what people say and do, and their presiding spirits are easily offended by disrespectful behavior. The interaction here is very intense, and the two orders of being coexist far more closely than in our own tradition. But animals do not use human language among themselves. They communicate with sounds which are considered their own form of language.

The closeness of animals to humans is reinforced by the fact that some animals are given funeral rituals following the basic form of those held for people, only on a smaller scale.... In these cases, at least, animal spirits are placated much as human souls are after death.

Most interesting of all is animal behavior interpreted to be religious. "Even animals have their taboos," a woman once told me. From her grandfather, she learned that gestating female beavers will not eat bark from the fork of a branch, because it is apparently tabooed for them. The late Chief Henry had told her of seeing a brown bear kill a ground squirrel, then tear out its heart, lungs, and windpipe and leave them on a rock. Again, the organs must have been taboo (*hutlaanee*)....

Nature Spirits and their Treatment

From the Distant Time stories, Koyukon people learn rules for proper conduct toward nature. But punishment for offenses against these rules is given by powerful spirits that are part of the living, present-day world. All animals, some plants, and some inanimate things have spirits, vaguely conceptualized essences that protect the welfare of their material counterparts. They are especially watchful for irreverent, insulting, or wasteful behavior toward living things. The spirits are not offended when people kill animals and use them, but they insist that these beings (or their remains) be treated with the deference owed to the sources of human life.

Not all spirits are possessed of equal power. Some animal species have very potent spirits called *biyeega hoolaanh*, which are easily provoked and highly vindictive. These dangerous spirits can bring serious harm to anyone who offends them, taking away luck in hunting or trapping and sometimes causing illness, disability, or even death. Animals possessed of such spirits include the brown bear, black bear, wolverine, lynx, wolf, and otter. The beaver and marmot have similarly powerful spirits but are not so vengeful.

The remaining mammals, birds, fish, and some plants and inanimate things have less powerful spirits. Although these are very real and can inflict punishment (usually bad luck in taking the species), all my instructors agreed that no Koyukon word exists for this kind of spirit. In response to my perplexed questioning, one person explained:

> *The animal and its spirit are one in the same thing. When you name the animal you're also naming its spirit. That's why some animal names are hutlaanee – like the ones women shouldn't say – because calling the animal's name is like calling its spirit. Just like we don't say a person's name after they die... it would be calling their spirit and could be dangerous for whoever did it.*

While most Koyukon adults seem to concur on the basic premises of their ideology, they vary widely in their opinions about the specifics and apparently do not feel inclined toward a rigid, systematized theology. This often left me confused, no doubt because of my Judeo-Christian background; and if my account of certain concepts is amorphous or inconsistent it properly reflects my learning experience. Koyukon people must find us painfully compulsive and conformist about our systems of belief.

...When an animal is mistreated, I was told, its individual spirit is affronted but all members of its species may become aloof from the offender. In former times, shamans could manipulate spirits for the opposite effect. They made dream visits to "animal houses" that were filled with spirits of a particular animal, then attracted them to certain parts of the country to enrich the harvest there.

Many other supernatural beings inhabit the traditional Koyukon world... but these seem to have little importance today. Perhaps Christian teachings displaced or undermined these beliefs, unlike those concerned with spirits of natural entities. Devices used to catch and kill animals – such as nets, snares, and deadfalls – also have powerful spirits (*biyeega hoolaanh*) with many associated taboos. Like the spirits of natural entities, these are still considered important today. For example, if a person borrows someone else's snare, he or she may take sick or die from its spirit power. Similarly, stealing a snared animal exposes the thief to grave danger from the spirits of both the snare and its catch.

Proper treatment of natural spirits involves hundreds of rules or taboos (*hutłaanee*), some applying to just one species and others having much more general effects. The rules fall into three main categories – first, treatment of living organisms; second, treatment of organisms (or parts of organisms) that are no longer alive; and third, treatment of nonliving entities or objects. I will briefly summarize these rules. . . .

Treatment of living organisms

Koyukon people follow some general rules in their behavior toward living animals. They avoid pointing at them, for example, because it shows disrespect, "like pointing or staring at a stranger." They also speak carefully about animals, especially avoiding boastful talk about hunting or trapping exploits.

A man who said he would trap many beavers was suddenly unable to catch any; and someone who bragged about bear hunting was later attacked and seriously hurt. In fact, bears are so powerful that every word spoken about them is carefully chosen. Trapped animals are also treated respectfully, and powerful ones like the wolf or wolverine may be addressed in special ways before they are killed. One man said that he always asks trapped animals for luck: "My animal, I hope that more of you will come my way."

Keeping wild animals as pets is also prohibited, except for species whose personality traits are valued in humans. A child who keeps a red fox will become mischievous, but if a boy raises a hawk owl he will acquire its hunting skill and cleanliness. People seldom keep pets, because they are likely to suffer, offending their spirits and causing illness or bad luck for those involved in their captivity. A woman told me of losing her small child about a year after the death of a baby hawk owl her family had kept. The tragic connection was clear.

Taking individual animals away to zoos, even catching and releasing them alive as part of studies, is a spiritual affront that can cause a species to shun the area. For this reason Koyukon people are opposed to wildlife research in their country if it involves live capture of animals.

> *We have respect for the animals. We don't keep them in cages or torture them, because we know the background of animals from the Distant Time. We know that the animal has a spirit – it used to be human – and we know all the things it did. It's not just an animal; it's lots more than that.*

Following from this, Koyukon people believe that animals must be treated humanely. The spirits are not offended because humans live by

hunting, but people must try to kill without causing suffering and to avoid losing wounded animals. A starving moose, mired in deep snow near Huslia, was fed daily until it regained strength and could walk away. Once a man found a black bear with cubs, driven from their den by groundwater, hopelessly starving in the deep snow. He ended their suffering, then dismembered and covered their unusable carcasses, lest he offend their spirits by killing without at least symbolic utilization. "We'll come back for this later," he told his companion, a placating remark that he knew he would not abide by.

Treatment of killed game

The rules for showing respect to killed animals and harvested plants are myriad. I will give some general principles and a few illustrations here . . . .

> Today I was told about a man who had once jokingly stuffed debris into the opened jaws of a dried pike head nailed on a cabin door to ward off bad spirits. His companions were horrified that he would open himself to retaliation from the animal's spirit. "When you do something like that – when you don't show respect for animals – it's just like making fun of the Bible." [Huslia journal, March 1977]

The remains of animals and plants are treated with the deference owed to something sacred. For example, when fur animals (such as mink, beaver, or wolf) are brought inside the house for skinning, their names should not be mentioned, nothing should be burned lest the smell offend their spirits, metallic noises should be avoided, and even if it is unfrozen and skinned the carcass should be kept indoors overnight. One way to prevent difficulties is to plug the nostrils of smell-sensitive animals like mink by smearing lard on them. Cloth may also be wrapped around an animal's head to protect it from offensive noises.

> *I had bad luck with fox this year. Come to think of it, I was using noisy power tools while I had a fox in the house. Guess that's why . . . it's got really sensitive ears. When you get bad luck like this you just have to let it wear off. There's nothing else you can do.*

There are also rules for proper butchering of game – for example, certain cuts that should be made or avoided for a particular species. There are rules for proper care of meat, such as keeping all meat covered when it is outside, protecting it from scavengers or from any insinuation that it is not respected. And a multitude of rules govern who eats an

animal or parts of it. Young adults and especially women of childbearing age are subject to a wide array of these. . . .

Finally, there are regulations to ensure that unusable parts of animals are respectfully disposed of. For example, bones of water animals such as beaver, muskrat, and mink should be cast into a lake or river. Bones of large land animals should be put in a dry place away from the village or completely burned in a remote spot. And the remains of small animals ought to be hung in bushes or burned. . . . Adherence has declined today, but many people scrupulously avoid leaving animal remains to rot on the ground (especially where someone might walk over them) or mixing them with household trash.

Punishment for ignoring or violating these regulations depends on the power of the living thing and the gravity of the offense. Spirit vengeance can be as severe as death or decades of bad luck in catching a species. Disregarding the prohibitions against eating certain foods usually causes clumsiness or other physical problems. Only old people who no longer hunt can eat red-necked grebe, for instance, because this bird is awkward on land. A young person who ate it would become slow and clumsy or would have children with these shortcomings. I never understood whether animal spirits cause such "contagious" reactions, but the innumerable food taboos are generally respected as an important way of protecting health and well-being.

Many of the rules apply to everyone, regardless of age or sex. But a large number of special restrictions apply to women between puberty and menopause. Koyukon women are skilled and active providers – they hunt, fish, trap, and gather on their own or along with men. Although they are competent and productive, they are somewhat limited by their possession of special power that can easily alienate or offend natural spirits.

The menses (*hutlaa*) has its own spirit that contains the essence of femininity, and it can bring bad luck with animals, feminize men and alienate animals from them, or even cause sickness or death. To avoid these dangers, Koyukon women were traditionally secluded during menstruation (some pubescent girls are still briefly sequestered at the first menstruation), and they continue to follow a multitude of special taboos regulating their use of animals and their behavior toward them.

Spirits of the physical world

Elements of the earth and sky are imbued with spirits and consciousness, much in the way of living things, and there are codes of proper behavior

toward them. Certain landforms have special powers that must be placated or shown deference, for example. Even the weather is aware: if a man brags that storms or cold cannot stop him from doing something, "the weather will take care of him good!" It will humble him with its power, "because it knows."

> *In falltime you'll hear the lakes make loud cracking noises after they freeze. It means they're asking for snow to cover them up, to protect them from the cold. When my father told me this, he said* everything *has life in it. He always used to tell us that.*

The earth itself is the source of a preeminent spiritual power called *sinh taala'* in Koyukon. This is the foundation of medicine power once used by shamans, and because of it the earth must be shown utmost respect. One person who was cured by medicine power years ago, for example, still abides by the shaman's instructions to avoid digging in the earth. Berry plants have special power because they are nurtured directly from the earth. "People are careful about things that grow close to the ground," I was told, "because the earth is so great."

The Manifestations of Luck

Luck is the powerful force that binds humanity to the nature spirits and their moral imperatives. For the Koyukon people, luck is a nearly tangible essence, an aura or condition that is "with" someone in certain circumstances or for particular purposes. Luck can be held permanently or it can be fleeting and elusive. It is an essential qualification for success – regardless of a person's skill, in the absence of luck there is no destiny except failure.

The source of luck is not clearly explained, but most people are apparently born with a certain measure of it. The difficulty is not so much in getting it as in keeping it. Luck is sustained by strictly following the rules of conduct toward natural things. People who lose their luck have clearly been punished by an offended spirit; people who possess luck are the beneficiaries of some force that creates it. Koyukon people express luck in the hunt by saying *bik'uhnaatltonh* – literally, "he has been taken care of."

> *If a person has good luck, catches game, it is because something created the world, and that is helping him to get what he needs.*

Luck, or the absence of it, is specific to particular animals or even certain activities. A woman who violates tanning taboos may fail in preparing hides. Each person is possessed (or dispossessed) of luck for

all the entities he or she interacts with. Thus a man told me that he had always been lucky hunting bears until he inadvertently treated one the wrong way. For many years afterward his luck was gone – he never took a single bear. Finally the effect wore off and since regaining his luck he has killed at least one bear each season.

Luck can be passed along to others, but it is a lot like money. The one who gives it up may be left with nothing. To illustrate, when beaver snaring was made legal years ago, it was very hard for young people to learn how to do it. The older men knew but were reluctant to reveal their ways, because telling someone how to make a trapping set also gives him your luck. Eventually people reach an age of inactivity, when their measure of luck becomes superfluous. Then they can confer their luck on others by simply wishing it so. This is why children often present their first-killed game to elders, and why young hunters give liberal shares of their catch to old men who no longer go out onto the land.

Possessions like sleds, fishnets, rifles, or snowshoes are also infused with luck. A man lamented to me that one of his high-caliber rifles had failed to kill a bear coming out of its den although it was at close range. He had to use another gun to finish the animal. This gun was "out of luck," he explained, and he suspected that a young woman had rendered it useless by stepping over it.

Putting on another person's mittens can either take away his luck or give him yours. Once I was traveling with a man whose hands became painfully cold, so I offered him my extra mittens. He finally took them, explaining that since I was leaving Huslia I could get along without luck in things like trapping. But a short while later he decided to take them off and endure the cold instead.

Luck is a finite entity, specific to each natural thing or even to certain activities. It can be lost, transferred, and recovered. Luck binds people to the code of proper behavior toward the natural world. And so success in living on the land involves far more than a mastery of technical skills. It requires that a sensitive balance be maintained between each person and the conscious forces of the environment. . . .

The Koyukon View of Nature

For traditional Koyukon people, the environment is both a natural and a supernatural realm. All that exists in nature is imbued with awareness and power; all events in nature are potentially manifestations of this power; all actions toward nature are mediated by consideration of its consciousness and sensitivity. The interchange between humans and

environment is based on an elaborate code of respect and morality, without which survival would be jeopardized. The Koyukon, while they are bound by the strictures of this system, can also manipulate its powers for their own benefit. Nature is a second society in which people live, a watchful and possessive one whose bounty is wrested as much by placation as by cleverness and craft.

Moving across the sprawl of wildland, through the forest and open muskeg, Koyukon people are ever conscious that they are among spirits. Each animal is far more than what can be seen; it is a personage and a personality, known from its legacy in stories of the Distant Time. It is a figure in the community of beings, once at least partially human, and even now possessed of attributes beyond outsiders' perception.

Not only the animals, but also the plants, the earth and landforms, the air, weather, and sky are spiritually invested. For each, the hunter knows an array of respectful gestures and deferential taboos that demand obedience. Violations against them will offend and alienate their spirits, bringing bad luck or illness, or worse if a powerful and vindictive being is treated irreverently.

Aware of these invisible forces and their manifestations, the Koyukon can protect and enhance their good fortune, can understand signs or warnings given them through natural events, and can sometimes influence the complexion of the environment to suit their desires. Everything in the Koyukon world lies partly in the realm beyond the senses, in the realm we would call supernatural.

From Gilbert Wilson, *Buffalo Bird Woman's Garden*

Reprinted from *Buffalo Bird Woman's Garden: Agriculture of the Hidatsa Indians* (St Paul: Minnesota Historical Society Press, 1987)

While European and Euro-American conquerors preferred to see all Indians as hunters, in fact, many American Indians were also formidable agriculturalists. Indeed, a whole range of wild plants were domesticated by American Indians, and their legacy is with us today. Maize, most beans, squash (including pumpkins), tomatoes, avocadoes, chocolate, and tobacco – to name just a few – developed from centuries of careful effort by Indians, most of them women, to make wild plants more useful to people. Buffalo Bird Woman was of the Hidatsa people, from the upper Missouri River in what is now North Dakota. Her people lived in this region for centuries before their conquest by the United States. Her reminiscence of cultivating the river bottoms in the latter 1800s is more than just one woman's personal story. It is testimony to centuries of planting and cultivating on the American continent. Various Indian peoples